



AND NOW THE SLOG OVERS

With elections due in three months, Modi goes on the offensive against his opponents using the development plank and a renewed Hindutva onslaught to win an unprecedented third term

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi doesn't need marketing gurus to sell himself and his Government to the people of the state. He is quite well-versed with the tricks of the trade. Five years ago, he had coined the term "Gujarat's Gaurav" which scripted his success story in the Assembly elections. As he prepares to face the ballot battle in another three months, he has armed himself with a new slogan "Vande (salute) Gujarat". He says these are not simple two words but a salute to the spirit of the state which wants to free itself from the fetters of poverty and reach new heights of development.

In 2002, a united Sangh Parivar and a post-Godhra Hindutva wave had fetched BJP 127 seats out of the total 182

in the state. This time, however, the ground realities have changed. Modi faces an uphill task with the Congress in a much better shape and the Sangh Parivar a divided house with powerful BJP leaders—Keshubhai Patel, Suresh Mehta, Kashiram Rana and many other seniors against him. But Modi's supporters are confident that the chief minister will romp home again on the strength of developmental work done by his Government and a renewed Hindutva onslaught following the Ram Sethu controversy, an issue that Modi has accepted with glee.

To woo the masses, he has his plans in place. He is not just shouting from the rooftop about the progress that Gujarat has made under his regime but is also making an attempt to create awareness about the same. The approach: direct contact pro-

gramme, the Vanthambhi (unstoppable) Vikas Yatra, wherein Modi and his men visit the villages and interact with the common man and explain the changes brought about by his Government in the past five years. It could be either the construction of a road, a drinking water borewell or any small thing that showcases his achievement. Not just that, Modi has been launching schemes at the drop of a hat—the Rs 15,000 crore Vanbandhu Kalyan Yojana aimed at the tribals and the Rs 11,000 crore Sagarkhedu Yojana for fishermen and the people of coastal areas—keeping the votebank in mind.

The chief minister is, however, silent on the charges being heaped upon him by his party rebels or political opponents and instead wants his work to do the talking and make